2026 / STAGE 5

Food Technology

STUDENT WORKBOOK



Read the food system. Question the claim. Show your thinking.

NAME _____ **CLASS** _____

Illustrative course image.

50 pages | A4 | 25 sheets, duplex long edge

THE PAPER COMPANION

Four questions about food

Use this book to read, annotate, compare evidence and develop responses. The website adds interactive practice. Google Classroom holds live teacher instructions, due dates and submissions.

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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Read the two facing theory pages for each section. Use the image prompt to observe, then turn to its evidence page. Keep drafts and revisions: the quality of your reasoning matters more than filling every line.

Source note. Original student explanations follow the 2026 class sequence and the NESA Food Technology 7-10 Syllabus (2019). Public evidence includes AIHW, WHO, DCCEEW, FSANZ and ACCC where relevant. Illustrative images are not photographs of this class.

MODULE 01 / FOCUS AREA

Food Equity

Who can obtain suitable food and safe water?



Illustrative course image. Use it as an opening observation, not as evidence of a local practical or event.

THREE LINES OF INQUIRY

1. **What food equity means**
2. **Barriers to food and water**
3. **Investigate and respond**

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

What do you already think matters here? Write one question that you would like evidence to answer.

MODULE 01 / SECTION 01 / READ

What food equity means

A full shop shelf does not guarantee that everyone can eat well.

Food equity is about fair opportunity to obtain enough safe, nutritious and suitable food. Food security describes reliable physical and economic access to food that supports health and wellbeing. These ideas are related, but they ask different questions: a food system can produce plenty overall while particular people remain unable to access what they need. A person's diet is shaped by more than preference or willpower. Money, location, transport, time, storage and the foods that a community recognises as appropriate all matter. The Food equity focus area in this course asks you to examine these conditions rather than judge individuals.

Availability means that food exists in shops, markets or other supply channels. Access means that a person can actually get it. A supermarket might stock fresh produce, yet the trip there could require a long journey or a fare a household cannot spare. Food can also be available and affordable on one day but unreliable after a lost shift, a delivery disruption or an extreme weather event. Reliability matters because a healthy food pattern depends on more than one lucky purchase. The question is whether people can keep obtaining suitable food over time.



Figure 1. A stocked shop and the journey to it are different parts of access. Illustrative course image.

LOOK CLOSELY

What does the image show about supply, and what can it not tell you about affordability?

MODULE 01 / SECTION 01 / CONNECT

What food equity means

Food quality and suitability also matter. Australia's dietary guidance recommends variety from five food groups, but a food choice may need to fit a person's culture, beliefs, allergies or other individual needs. A cheap item is not automatically an equitable solution if it provides little useful nutrition or cannot be used by the people it is intended for. Equally, a nutritious product does not solve a problem when its price or travel cost keeps it out of reach. Students should compare the whole situation: choice, cost, distance, quality, dignity and continuity.

Consider two households living near the same shop. One has reliable income, a vehicle and space to store food; the other has irregular work, no car and limited storage. Identical shelf prices can produce very different real access. This is why an equity response may remove a barrier, such as transport, rather than simply tell people what to buy. Evidence about the barrier should come before a proposed solution. The aim is fair access, not identical meals for everyone.



Figure 2. The same food offer can be easier for one household to use than another. Illustrative course image.

WORDS TO USE

Food equity. Fair opportunity for people to obtain enough safe, nutritious and suitable food.

Food security. Reliable physical and economic access to food that supports health and wellbeing.

Availability. Whether a suitable food is present in the supply system.

Access. Whether a person can realistically obtain and use that food.

Source pathway: class sequence, NESA 2019 and linked public evidence

MODULE 01 / SECTION 01 / EVIDENCE

Access comparison

WORKED EXAMPLE / A WAY TO REASON

A fruit shop may be close in kilometres but effectively distant if there is no affordable transport. Compare travel time and cost as well as the shelf price before judging access.

YOUR TASK

Explain how two people can face different food access even when they live near the same well-stocked shop. Recommend one response to a documented barrier and justify why it could improve equity.

1. Distinguish food availability from real access in your example.

2. Identify at least two conditions that could create different experiences.

3. Choose one barrier that evidence could test and propose a targeted response.

4. Explain how you would check whether access improved over time.

Factor	Household A	Household B
Travel		
Total cost		
Suitability		
Reliable supply		

FINAL JUDGEMENT / ACCESS AND JUSTIFIED RESPONSE

A STRONG RESPONSE

- Uses food equity and food security accurately without blaming people.
- Connects a specific barrier, response and measurable sign of improvement.

MODULE 01 / SECTION 02 / READ

Barriers to food and water

Food access depends on connected systems, including income, transport and safe water.

A barrier is a condition that makes suitable food harder to obtain or use. Cost can be the shelf price, but also transport, electricity, time away from paid work or the equipment needed to store and prepare food. Limited transport may reduce choice or make frequent trips difficult. A person in a remote area can face different supply conditions from a person near several shops. These are patterns to investigate, not reasons to assume that every person in one place has the same experience. Good analysis names the barrier and gathers evidence about its size.

Supply can also change. Extreme weather, disrupted delivery or price changes may affect what reaches shops and what households can buy. A household with spare money and storage may be able to adapt; another household may have less room to respond. This means food equity includes resilience: how well access continues when circumstances change. A short-term shortage and a long-term affordability problem need different responses. Mapping where a disruption occurs helps avoid treating all barriers as if they were the same.



Figure 3. Food and water depend on connected supply systems. Illustrative course image.

LOOK CLOSELY

Where could a disruption affect the journey from supply to household?

MODULE 01 / SECTION 02 / CONNECT

Barriers to food and water

Safe water is part of this picture. Water is needed for drinking and food production, and reliable safe water supports health. The World Health Organization describes equitable drinking-water access in terms of safety, affordability and availability when needed. If water is distant, unreliable or unaffordable, food choices and daily life are affected too. Water problems cannot be reduced to how much rain falls: infrastructure, management and cost also shape access. Comparing communities requires attention to these connected factors, and care not to treat a global statistic as a fact about a specific Australian community.

Desalination is one possible water-supply response. It can turn seawater or brackish water into drinking water, but a proposal still has to be judged against local needs, energy use, cost, environmental effects and water-quality management. It does not by itself make food affordable or improve transport. Another location might need a different mix of responses. The useful question is: which barrier does an intervention address, who benefits, and what other effects must be checked? A fair solution may combine several actions and should be reviewed with the people affected.



Figure 4. A water response should be judged against the barrier it actually addresses. Illustrative course image.

WORDS TO USE

Barrier. A condition that limits someone's ability to obtain or use suitable food or water.

Resilience. The ability of access or supply to continue or recover when conditions change.

Safe water. Water suitable for drinking and everyday uses under appropriate management.

Desalination. A process that removes salts from seawater or brackish water as part of a managed water supply.

Source pathway: class sequence, NESA 2019 and linked public evidence

MODULE 01 / SECTION 02 / EVIDENCE

Barrier to response

WORKED EXAMPLE / A WAY TO REASON

If a storm interrupts deliveries, compare a short-term supply response with a longer-term plan for reliable transport. The two actions address different time scales.

YOUR TASK

A community reports unreliable access to affordable food and safe water after repeated supply disruptions. Compare two possible responses, explain what each would address, and evaluate what evidence is needed before recommending one or a combination.

1. Separate the food and water barriers and identify any links between them.

2. Compare a short-term response with a longer-term response.

3. Consider cost, reliability, who benefits and possible trade-offs.

4. State the local evidence needed to justify and review the recommendation.

BARRIER	EFFECT ON ACCESS	POSSIBLE RESPONSE	TRADE-OFF

FINAL COMPARISON / PREFERRED RESPONSE AND EVIDENCE

A STRONG RESPONSE

- Explains how connected barriers affect equitable access without unsupported local claims.
- Makes a reasoned recommendation that matches each response to an identified barrier.

MODULE 01 / SECTION 03 / READ

Investigate and respond

A useful food equity response begins with a precise question and ends with evidence of change.

Investigation starts by defining whose access is being considered, what food or water need matters, and over what period. A claim such as ‘this area has good food access’ is too broad on its own. Better questions ask how long a journey takes, whether nutritious and suitable options are regularly available, and how total costs compare with the resources people have. Use a mix of evidence: public data can reveal a pattern, a map can show distance, and respectful consultation can reveal obstacles that the map misses. Protect people’s privacy and avoid collecting personal stories that the investigation does not need.

Next, distinguish observation from inference. A shop being present is an observation; concluding that everyone can use it is an inference requiring more evidence. Older figures may explain a historical argument but should not be presented as current conditions. Compare the date, source, geographical scale and definition behind each figure. A national food-insecurity figure cannot automatically describe one town. Evidence may also be incomplete or conflicting. State that uncertainty openly rather than inventing precision.



Figure 5. A map is one piece of evidence, not the whole answer. Illustrative course image.

LOOK CLOSELY

Which detail could be observed directly, and which conclusion needs more evidence?

MODULE 01 / SECTION 03 / CONNECT

Investigate and respond

An effective response should match a demonstrated barrier. If suitable food is available but travel is the problem, a transport or delivery option could be tested. If food is accessible but too expensive, a price or income-related response may be more relevant. If availability is unreliable, supply arrangements and storage might matter. A response designed with the affected community is more likely to fit actual needs and preserve dignity than one chosen from assumptions. It should also be realistic about the people and organisations needed to carry it out.

Evaluation asks whether conditions improved, for whom and for how long. Possible indicators include a shorter journey, more reliable stock, a lower total cost to obtain suitable food, or feedback that choices now fit people's needs. Each indicator has a limit: a lower shelf price may hide travel cost, while more deliveries may still miss some households. Review unintended effects and revise the response if necessary. A strong conclusion describes what the evidence supports, what remains unknown and the next question worth testing.



Figure 6. A strong claim names its source, scale, date and limit. Illustrative course image.

WORDS TO USE

Observation. Something directly recorded, such as a shop location or listed price.

Inference. A conclusion drawn from observations that needs reasoning and supporting evidence.

Indicator. A measure used to judge whether a condition has changed.

Trade-off. A possible cost or drawback weighed against a benefit.

Source pathway: class sequence, NESA 2019 and linked public evidence

MODULE 01 / SECTION 03 / EVIDENCE

Evidence ledger

WORKED EXAMPLE / A WAY TO REASON

A map shows a supermarket 2 km away. Before calling it accessible, investigate the route, transport, opening hours, total cost and whether suitable food is consistently stocked.

YOUR TASK

Evaluate a proposed 'better food access' plan that opens a new shop. Explain what evidence would show whether it helps the intended community, identify two limits of the plan, and recommend one adjustment.

1. State the claim and separate what is known from what is assumed.
2. Choose evidence about affordability, transport, suitability and reliability.
3. Identify two plausible limits without assuming they apply to everyone.
4. Recommend an adjustment and an indicator for reviewing its effect.

Claim	Evidence	Limit
Shop location		
Total cost		
Suitable range		
Next check		

FINAL EVALUATION / CLAIM, LIMIT AND ADJUSTMENT

A STRONG RESPONSE

- Uses dated, scale-appropriate evidence and labels any uncertainty.
- Evaluates benefits and limits before making a justified adjustment.

MODULE 01 / DECISION STUDIO

An access plan with evidence



Illustrative scene for reasoning; it does not depict this class or a completed task.

Practice scenario: a community group wants to improve access to suitable food after residents report expensive journeys and unreliable stock. No one response has been selected.

BUILD THE DECISION

1. State the most useful evidence to collect first.

2. Compare a travel response and a supply response.

3. Recommend what to test, for whom, and how success could be measured.

EVIDENCE / OPTION / REASON / NEXT CHECK

Practice evidence: use the teacher's current Classroom instructions for any formal task.

MODULE 01 / REVIEW AND REFLECT

What can you now explain?

Circle one answer for each check, then use the writing space to correct or extend an idea. These are formative practice questions.

01. A meal pack is inexpensive but unsuitable for a family's dietary needs. What does this show?

- ○ A. Suitability must be considered alongside price.
- ○ B. Low price should be judged first; dietary fit can be considered after purchase.
- ○ C. A wider range of foods in the shop would make this meal pack suitable.

02. What does desalination directly address?

- ○ A. Removing microbes from any freshwater source.
- ○ B. The supply of water from saline sources.
- ○ C. Storing rainfall for use during dry periods.

03. Which statement is an inference rather than an observation?

- ○ A. The bus timetable lists two weekday services.
- ○ B. Everyone nearby can shop there easily.
- ○ C. The shop lists bread at $4 today.

CORRECT OR EXTEND ONE ANSWER

EVIDENCE KEPT IN THIS MODULE

- ☐ I can point to a source or observation.
- ☐ I have compared more than one factor.
- ☐ I have named a limit or unanswered question.

ONE IDEA I WOULD IMPROVE AFTER FEEDBACK

MODULE 02 / FOCUS AREA

Food Trends

Why does a food idea catch on, and how do we test its claims?



Illustrative course image. Use it as an opening observation, not as evidence of a local practical or event.

THREE LINES OF INQUIRY

1. **Why food trends emerge**
2. **Local produce, waste and value adding**
3. **Evaluate a food trend**

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

What do you already think matters here? Write one question that you would like evidence to answer.

MODULE 02 / SECTION 01 / READ

Why food trends emerge

A trend can become popular quickly; its popularity is not proof that it suits every person.

A food trend is a pattern of interest or behaviour in food selection, service or presentation that gains attention over time. The 2019 Food Technology focus area asks students to consider why trends appeal to consumers and how they shape food choices. Some trends are long-running; others may fade after a burst of publicity. A trend can spread because of changing lifestyles, social media, a new product, concern about health, interest in the environment, cultural exchange or a need for convenience. Several influences often work together, so there is rarely one simple cause.

Imagine a café advertising a new vegetable-based meal. It may appeal to people wanting a different flavour, an option they perceive as healthier, a particular dietary pattern, or a meal that looks good in a photograph. These are possible reasons for interest, not evidence that the meal is automatically more nutritious or sustainable. Trend words such as ‘natural’, ‘local’ or ‘high protein’ can influence first impressions. Ask what each word actually means in the specific product and what information would test the implied benefit. A product can suit one person’s needs and not another’s.



Figure 7. Presentation can attract attention before any benefit is tested. Illustrative course image.

LOOK CLOSELY

Which visible feature might drive attention without proving a health benefit?

MODULE 02 / SECTION 01 / CONNECT

Why food trends emerge

Consumers also influence businesses. When enough customers seek an option, businesses may change menus, packaging or marketing. Businesses can then promote those products and further shape demand. Price, access, culture, allergies and personal needs affect who can participate. A trend presented as universal may be out of reach for some people or unsuitable for their needs. The Australian dietary guidance is a useful broader reference: a healthy eating pattern draws on variety across the five food groups rather than one fashionable ingredient or product.

The 2026 class explores mindful eating, local produce, food miles, waste, value adding and dietary trends. Use those topics as questions, not as slogans. For example, mindful eating can prompt attention to the experience of eating, while an evidence-based nutrition judgement still needs information about the food and the person's needs. A useful investigation separates a trend's appeal from its claimed outcomes. Describe who may benefit, what might limit participation and what evidence would change your judgement.



Figure 8. Ask what makes a new food appealing, and to whom. Illustrative course image.

WORDS TO USE

Food trend. A pattern of interest or behaviour affecting food selection, service or presentation.

Consumer demand. The choices and preferences that influence which products or services businesses offer.

Claim. A statement about a product that should be interpreted and checked against evidence.

Dietary pattern. The overall combination of foods and drinks a person usually consumes.

Source pathway: class sequence, NESA 2019 and linked public evidence

MODULE 02 / SECTION 01 / EVIDENCE

Trend pathway

WORKED EXAMPLE / A WAY TO REASON

A menu calls a meal 'local and healthy'. Identify two separate claims. Check origin evidence for 'local' and relevant nutrition information for 'healthy' rather than treating the phrase as one proven fact.

YOUR TASK

Choose a current or plausible food trend and explain why it might spread. Evaluate two claims made about it and decide what evidence would be needed before recommending it to a particular group of consumers.

1. Describe the trend and at least two influences on its appeal.

2. Separate what is observed from health or environmental claims.

3. Consider price, access and different consumer needs.

4. State the evidence that would support or weaken your recommendation.

DRIVER	PROMOTION	CONSUMER INTEREST	CLAIM TO TEST

FINAL DECISION / WHO BENEFITS AND WHAT TO TEST

A STRONG RESPONSE

- Explains how consumer demand and promotion can interact.
- Uses evidence and limits instead of treating popularity as proof.

MODULE 02 / SECTION 02 / READ

Local produce, waste and value adding

Local origin, less waste and greater product value are related ideas, but each needs its own evidence.

Local produce generally means food grown or made relatively near the place where it is sold or eaten. What counts as ‘local’ depends on the boundary being used: a town, region or state can produce different answers. The class explores food miles, the distance food travels from production to consumption. Distance is useful to ask about, especially when comparing transport routes, but it is not a complete measure of environmental impact. Production, storage, packaging, transport type and waste can all matter. A shorter route does not automatically prove a smaller overall impact.

Food waste is food intended for people that is thrown away. It can occur at farms, during processing and distribution, in retail and hospitality, and at home. Waste represents lost food and the resources used to produce and move it. Australia’s national strategy aims to reduce food waste across the supply chain, so responsibility is shared rather than assigned only to households. A useful first question is where and why a specific loss occurs. Damage during transport, an unsuitable order size and unused food at home call for different responses.



Figure 9. A product journey includes production, storage, transport and use. Illustrative course image.

LOOK CLOSELY

Mark one point where edible food might be lost and one possible new use.

MODULE 02 / SECTION 02 / CONNECT

Local produce, waste and value adding

Value adding means changing a product or service so it offers something consumers find useful and may be willing to pay for. A producer might turn suitable surplus fruit into another saleable product, or a business might offer a different presentation or convenient format. That idea can reduce some waste when it uses food that otherwise would be discarded, but it is not automatically a waste solution. Processing may need extra materials, energy, labour, packaging and distribution. The result still needs to be wanted by consumers and priced within reach of its intended market.

Suppose a grower has fruit that is sound but does not meet a retailer's appearance preference. Selling it differently or using it in another product are possible pathways to investigate. Compare how much edible food each pathway saves, what it costs, the resources it uses and who can afford the final product. Avoid claiming that the 'local' or 'upcycled' option is always best. A good decision traces the entire pathway and names the evidence still needed. In practical work, the teacher's approved instructions and food-safety arrangements control what students actually make.



Figure 10. Value adding can create new uses, but also new resource demands. Illustrative course image.

WORDS TO USE

Food miles. The distance food travels between production and consumption.

Food waste. Food intended for human consumption that is thrown away.

Value adding. Changing a product or service to offer added usefulness or market appeal.

Supply chain. The connected steps that bring food from production to consumers.

Source pathway: class sequence, NESA 2019 and linked public evidence

MODULE 02 / SECTION 02 / EVIDENCE

Trace the journey

WORKED EXAMPLE / A WAY TO REASON

A ‘local’ tomato and a tomato from another region cannot be compared fairly using distance alone. Ask about how each was produced, stored, moved and wasted before making an environmental claim.

YOUR TASK

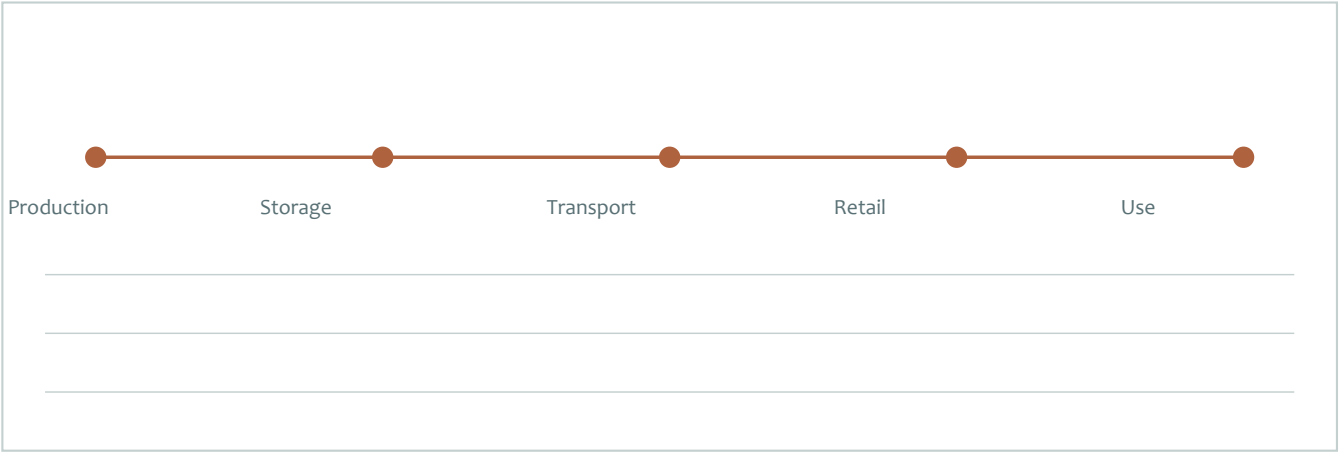
Compare two ways a business could use sound surplus produce. Evaluate likely effects on food waste, consumer value, affordability and resource use, then recommend what evidence the business should gather before choosing.

1. Identify where the surplus arises and why it might be wasted.

2. Explain how each option adds value or changes access.

3. Compare waste avoided with added energy, packaging, labour or transport.

4. Choose useful measures and state any uncertainty.



FINAL RECOMMENDATION / TRADE-OFFS ACROSS THE JOURNEY

A STRONG RESPONSE

- Treats food miles and local origin as partial evidence rather than complete environmental proof.
- Makes a justified recommendation using more than one criterion.

MODULE 02 / SECTION 03 / READ

Evaluate a food trend

A good judgement names the consumer, tests the claim and explains the trade-offs.

To evaluate a food trend, start with a clear decision: is the idea suitable for a particular consumer or purpose? Record exactly what is being claimed and by whom. Separate a product's features, such as ingredients or price, from promotional language such as 'better for you' or 'green'. A comparison needs a fair reference point. 'Lower sugar' only becomes meaningful when you know lower than what, measured in which amount, and whether other relevant qualities differ. An attractive photograph or a high number of online views tells you about presentation and reach, not necessarily quality.

For packaged foods, the nutrition information panel can help compare similar products. Food Standards Australia New Zealand explains that the per 100 g or 100 mL column is useful for comparison because serving sizes can differ between brands. Read the ingredient list and relevant allergen information when suitability is at issue. A claim such as 'no added sugar' does not mean a product has no sugars; the label and context still matter. The Australian dietary guidance also asks students to think about their overall pattern of eating, rather than treating one product as a shortcut to health.



Figure 11. Front-of-pack messages invite closer reading. Illustrative course image.

LOOK CLOSELY

What would you read before accepting a front-of-pack claim?

MODULE 02 / SECTION 03 / CONNECT

Evaluate a food trend

Environmental claims need similar care. ‘Local’ gives an origin clue but does not by itself measure total impact. ‘Less waste’ should be supported by information about what food was saved and any new resources used. Australia’s consumer regulator advises that environmental claims be accurate and backed by evidence. Ask whether a claim is specific, whether a reliable source supports it, and whether important limitations are missing. Avoid a false choice between two extremes: a trend can have genuine benefits while still carrying costs or uncertainty.

A decision also depends on the consumer and the setting. Price, availability, cultural fit, accessibility and intended use all affect suitability. Build a simple evidence table with claim, source, comparison and limitation. Then make a conditional judgement: ‘For this group, this option may work because…, provided that…’. The posted Food Trends task and its live instructions remain in Google Classroom; this section helps you reason about choices, but it does not replace the teacher’s task. Revisit the evidence if new information appears.



Figure 12. Compare similar products on a common quantity, then consider the consumer. Illustrative course image.

WORDS TO USE

Nutrition information panel. A standard food label panel showing average energy and listed nutrients per serve and per 100 g or 100 mL.

Fair comparison. A comparison using a relevant common measure and similar products or circumstances.

Environmental claim. A statement about a product’s effect on the environment that needs support.

Conditional judgement. A conclusion that states who it applies to and the conditions or uncertainties that matter.

Source pathway: class sequence, NESA 2019 and linked public evidence

MODULE 02 / SECTION 03 / EVIDENCE

Test three claims

WORKED EXAMPLE / A WAY TO REASON

Two similar snacks list different serving sizes. Compare the same nutrient per 100 g first, then consider the actual amount eaten, price, ingredients and the needs of the intended consumer.

YOUR TASK

A business promotes a new 'local, low-waste, healthier' snack. Evaluate those three claims for a defined group of consumers and make a conditional recommendation using the evidence you would need.

1. Identify the intended consumers and the decision they face.

2. Test the origin, waste and nutrition claims separately using fair comparisons.

3. Consider price, availability, suitability and possible trade-offs.

4. Write a conditional conclusion and name at least one unresolved question.

Claim	Evidence needed	Limit
Local		
Low waste		
Healthier		
Recommendation		

FINAL CONDITIONAL RECOMMENDATION / UNRESOLVED QUESTION

A STRONG RESPONSE

- Uses relevant sources and common measures to assess each claim.
- Explains limits and avoids turning a broad marketing phrase into a fact.

MODULE 02 / DECISION STUDIO

A trend pitch under scrutiny



Illustrative scene for reasoning; it does not depict this class or a completed task.

Practice scenario: a café wants to promote a new snack as local, lower waste and suitable for a wider range of customers. The claims have not yet been verified.

BUILD THE DECISION

1. Separate the three claims and name evidence for each.

2. Identify one possible trade-off and one access question.

3. Write a conditional recommendation for the café.

EVIDENCE / OPTION / REASON / NEXT CHECK

Practice evidence: use the teacher's current Classroom instructions for any formal task.

MODULE 02 / REVIEW AND REFLECT

What can you now explain?

Circle one answer for each check, then use the writing space to correct or extend an idea. These are formative practice questions.

01. Why can a ‘high protein’ label require closer reading?

- ○ A. It tells you the whole product is balanced across the food groups.
- ○ B. A claim may need context and product information.
- ○ C. It means the listed serving is the amount everyone should eat.

02. What is the best first question for reducing a specific food loss?

- ○ A. Where and why is the food being discarded?
- ○ B. Choose the most visible waste item for a publicity campaign.
- ○ C. Estimate consumer attitudes before finding where the loss occurs.

03. Why might ingredient and allergen information matter in trend evaluation?

- ○ A. A health claim on the front makes the ingredient list unnecessary.
- ○ B. If a food fits a trend, it fits all consumers’ dietary requirements.
- ○ C. Suitability depends on the consumer’s needs.

CORRECT OR EXTEND ONE ANSWER

EVIDENCE KEPT IN THIS MODULE

- ☐ I can point to a source or observation.
- ☐ I have compared more than one factor.
- ☐ I have named a limit or unanswered question.

ONE IDEA I WOULD IMPROVE AFTER FEEDBACK

MODULE 03 / FOCUS AREA

Food for Special Occasions

How does food express the meaning of an occasion?



Illustrative course image. Use it as an opening observation, not as evidence of a local practical or event.

THREE LINES OF INQUIRY

1. **Food, identity and significance**
2. **Celebrations across time and place**
3. **Plan for an occasion**

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

What do you already think matters here? Write one question that you would like evidence to answer.

MODULE 03 / SECTION 01 / READ

Food, identity and significance

The meaning of a celebration food comes from people and context, not from an ingredient alone.

Food does more than meet a physical need. Sharing, offering and preparing it can welcome people, mark a milestone or show care. A familiar dish may recall a person, place or family story. The same food might be ordinary on one day and deeply significant on another because of who prepares it, who gathers and what they are remembering. Food significance therefore cannot be judged by price, complexity or appearance alone. To understand it, ask what the food means to the people involved.

Occasions can be social, family, cultural, religious or historical; many fit more than one description. A birthday may centre on a family tradition. A community event may mark a shared history. Some guests may follow religious food practices while others within the same community choose differently. Identity is personal as well as collective, so one person cannot speak for every member of a group. Respectful investigation uses reliable accounts and, where possible, the voices of people who take part. It avoids claiming that one dish represents an entire culture.



Figure 13. Food meaning is connected to people and a particular occasion. Illustrative course image.

LOOK CLOSELY

What clues suggest that the same dish may mean different things to guests?

MODULE 03 / SECTION 01 / CONNECT

Food, identity and significance

Food choices communicate meaning through more than a name. Ingredients, serving style, colour, aroma and the act of eating together can all contribute. A food that is easy to share may encourage conversation; a carefully presented portion may suit a formal gathering. These are design possibilities, not rules. A planner needs to consider the actual setting and guests before deciding which features matter. Presentation should support the purpose of the event while keeping the food suitable for those who will eat it.

When you explain the significance of a food, separate evidence from assumption. Name the occasion and the group or person whose practice you are discussing, cite where the information came from and explain the connection rather than simply listing ingredients. Consider whose perspective is missing. A thoughtful choice also asks whether guests can access and enjoy the food, including guests with dietary needs. Significance and inclusion belong together: a menu can honour a tradition while offering considered choices for the people present.



Figure 14. A shared food can hold different meanings for different people. Illustrative course image.

WORDS TO USE

Food significance. The meaning people attach to food in a particular personal or social context.

Identity. A person's or group's sense of who they are, shaped by experiences and relationships.

Tradition. A practice passed on and sometimes adapted across time or generations.

Source pathway: class sequence, NESA 2019 and linked public evidence

MODULE 03 / SECTION 01 / EVIDENCE

Meaning map

WORKED EXAMPLE / A WAY TO REASON

At a family reunion, a shared dish may matter because relatives associate it with a grandparent. The explanation should name that family connection; it should not claim the dish means the same thing to everyone from the family's cultural background.

YOUR TASK

Explain how a planner could choose food that has meaning for a family or community occasion while respecting the different people attending.

1. Name an occasion and explain whose perspective you would seek.

2. Connect one possible food or serving choice to the occasion's meaning, with the type of evidence you would use.

3. Explain how you would check guests' needs and adapt the plan without assuming that one tradition fits everyone.

ANNOTATE YOUR MAP WITH PEOPLE, OCCASION AND EVIDENCE

FINAL EXPLANATION / MEANING AND GUEST ADAPTATIONS

A STRONG RESPONSE

- Links a food decision to people and occasion using a justified source, rather than appearance or stereotype.
- Explains at least one inclusive adjustment and acknowledges variation within groups.

MODULE 03 / SECTION 02 / READ

Celebrations across time and place

Traditions can continue, change and travel; a careful comparison asks what changed and why.

Celebration foods have histories. Families and communities pass on knowledge, but their menus are not frozen in time. Migration, trade, technology, local ingredients, cost and changing household routines can alter what is available and how people prepare or serve food. A new version may still carry a familiar purpose, such as welcoming visitors or marking the start of a year. Describing change as a loss of 'real' tradition is often too simple. Ask which elements people choose to preserve, which they adapt and why.

Comparing celebrations across places requires more than listing dishes. New Year is an example: the timing, meaning and foods can differ between communities, and people within a community may celebrate in different ways. A useful comparison names the specific community, place and time described by a trustworthy source. It looks at the purpose of the food, who prepares or shares it, the setting, and any evidence of change. It also avoids treating one image or one household as a complete picture of a nation.



Figure 15. Traditions may continue while ingredients and settings change. Illustrative course image.

LOOK CLOSELY

Which detail might change across time or place while an occasion retains meaning?

MODULE 03 / SECTION 02 / CONNECT

Celebrations across time and place

Global connections can make ingredients and ideas more available. A family may use a local ingredient in a remembered dish, or a food business may adapt a menu for its customers. These choices can create new forms of celebration food. They can also raise questions about who gets credit, whether a food is described accurately and whether its cultural context has been removed. A respectful account attributes the people or community behind an idea and does not rank versions as more or less authentic without evidence from those involved.

History is built from evidence. A dated menu, a first-hand recollection, an archive photograph and a contemporary article can each answer different questions. An old menu may show what was listed or planned for one event, but not what was actually served or eaten. A present-day recollection may explain meaning, but memory has limits. Cross-check sources and distinguish what they show from what you infer. When planning for real guests, historical examples can inspire questions, not prescribe a menu. Current preferences, resources and dietary needs still matter.



Figure 16. Compare an earlier account with a current practice before drawing a conclusion. Illustrative course image.

WORDS TO USE

Adaptation. A change to a practice or food that responds to a new context while possibly keeping its purpose.

First-hand account. A description from someone who directly experienced an event or practice.

Globalisation. Growing connections through which people, ingredients and food ideas move between places.

Source pathway: class sequence, NESA 2019 and linked public evidence

MODULE 03 / SECTION 02 / EVIDENCE

Continuity and change

WORKED EXAMPLE / A WAY TO REASON

A family now living in NSW might use a locally available ingredient in a dish linked to a yearly gathering. Compare the current choice with a family account of an earlier version: identify what changed, what meaning stayed and what remains uncertain.

YOUR TASK

Compare how a celebration food could keep a familiar meaning while changing across time or place, and evaluate what evidence would support your explanation.

1. Describe a hypothetical or well-sourced example, naming the people, place and occasion.

2. Explain two possible reasons for change and one purpose that may continue.

3. Identify what a dated source and a first-hand account could each show, and one limit of either source.



FINAL COMPARISON / CHANGE, CONTINUITY AND EVIDENCE

A STRONG RESPONSE

- Explains continuity and change without claiming one version represents everyone.
- Uses at least two evidence types and distinguishes a supported observation from an inference.

MODULE 03 / SECTION 03 / READ

Plan for an occasion

A strong occasion menu begins with a brief and can be explained against clear criteria.

Planning starts with a design brief: what is the occasion, who is attending, where will food be served and what experience should it create? A small family gathering and a large community function may need different service approaches even if they share a theme. The number and characteristics of diners, time, money, available ingredients, equipment and people's skills all affect what is feasible. A menu should be judged against these real constraints, not only against a photograph of a finished dish.

Several criteria work together. Appeal includes colour, aroma, flavour, texture and presentation, while nutritional value asks whether the range of choices is appropriate for the guests and occasion. Cultural or religious considerations and personal preferences need to be investigated, not guessed. A dietary requirement, especially a food allergy, requires accurate information and careful communication. An attractive label such as 'allergen free' is not a substitute for checking ingredients and the possibility of unintended allergen contact. Follow the teacher's current practical and food-safety directions for any class preparation; a website plan cannot certify a meal as safe for a particular person.



Figure 17. A menu begins with the people and purpose of the occasion. Illustrative course image.

LOOK CLOSELY

How could the planner check that the event food fits its guests?

MODULE 03 / SECTION 03 / CONNECT

Plan for an occasion

A menu is a coordinated set of choices. Variety can help guests find a suitable option, but extra dishes also consume money, time and work space. Decide what each item contributes and whether the group can present it consistently. A workflow plan then sequences the work and allocates responsibilities: which tasks depend on others, what must be ready before service and who communicates changes. The purpose is to see pressure points before the event. It is not a fixed recipe or a replacement for local safety instructions.

Evaluation uses the brief as a test. Before choosing, compare possible menus against criteria such as meaning, guest suitability, resources, presentation and service. After a trial or event, gather evidence rather than relying on 'it looked good': note feedback, timing, waste and whether people could make informed choices. Explain trade-offs. A simpler menu may better meet the brief if it can be produced and served reliably. An improvement should say what would change and why that change would better serve the actual guests.



Figure 18. Planning weighs guest needs, resources and the desired atmosphere. Illustrative course image.

WORDS TO USE

Design brief. A short description of the occasion, users, purpose and constraints a food solution must address.

Criterion. A stated measure used to compare and evaluate a proposed solution.

Workflow. The order of connected tasks and responsibilities needed to deliver a food solution.

Source pathway: class sequence, NESA 2019 and linked public evidence

MODULE 03 / SECTION 03 / EVIDENCE

Occasion menu brief

WORKED EXAMPLE / A WAY TO REASON

For a community afternoon event, a planner compares two hypothetical menus against guest information, available resources and desired atmosphere. A shorter menu might be selected if the team can serve it more reliably and offer clearer dietary information.

YOUR TASK

Justify a menu approach for a hypothetical special occasion and evaluate one trade-off in your choice.

1. Define the occasion, setting, diners and two important constraints.

2. Explain how your menu approach addresses meaning, appeal, nutritional consideration and guest needs.

3. Identify one resource or service trade-off, explain your choice and describe evidence you would gather afterwards.

OPTION A	OPTION B

FINAL MENU JUDGEMENT / TRADE-OFF AND NEXT EVIDENCE

A STRONG RESPONSE

- Uses explicit criteria from the brief to justify the menu rather than listing attractive foods.
- Addresses dietary information responsibly and evaluates a trade-off with a possible evidence-based improvement.

MODULE 03 / DECISION STUDIO

Design for a meaningful gathering



Illustrative scene for reasoning; it does not depict this class or a completed task.

Practice scenario: a community group is planning an afternoon gathering. Guests may bring different traditions, preferences and dietary needs; the menu has not been decided.

BUILD THE DECISION

1. Gather information about people and the occasion.

2. Sketch two possible menu approaches without assuming one tradition for everyone.

3. Explain a trade-off and the feedback you would seek.

EVIDENCE / OPTION / REASON / NEXT CHECK

Practice evidence: use the teacher's current Classroom instructions for any formal task.

MODULE 03 / REVIEW AND REFLECT

What can you now explain?

Circle one answer for each check, then use the writing space to correct or extend an idea. These are formative practice questions.

01. A planner wants food that helps unfamiliar guests talk together. Which feature is most relevant to that purpose?

- ○ A. An individually plated formal course that focuses attention on presentation.
- ○ B. A familiar range of dishes served separately to each guest.
- ○ C. A serving approach that invites sharing and conversation.

02. A current article describes a community celebration, but no participant is quoted. What would strengthen an account of its meaning?

- ○ A. A longer outside report with more description of the dishes and setting.
- ○ B. A first-hand account from a participant, considered alongside the article.
- ○ C. A larger set of event photographs without accounts from people involved.

03. Why might adding a fifth dish weaken an otherwise strong menu?

- ○ A. It may stretch time and resources without meeting an unmet guest need.
- ○ B. Because adding a dish always reduces the nutritional value of the menu.
- ○ C. Because a longer menu necessarily loses the event's theme, even when the dish fits it.

CORRECT OR EXTEND ONE ANSWER

EVIDENCE KEPT IN THIS MODULE

- ☐ I can point to a source or observation.
- ☐ I have compared more than one factor.
- ☐ I have named a limit or unanswered question.

ONE IDEA I WOULD IMPROVE AFTER FEEDBACK

MODULE 04 / FOCUS AREA

Food Service and Catering

How do a menu, people and resources work together?



Illustrative course image. Use it as an opening observation, not as evidence of a local practical or event.

THREE LINES OF INQUIRY

1. **Service settings and customers**
2. **Menus, teams and costs**
3. **Functional properties and review**

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

What do you already think matters here? Write one question that you would like evidence to answer.

MODULE 04 / SECTION 01 / READ

Service settings and customers

Food service takes many forms; the customer, setting and service promise shape the operation.

A school canteen, café, restaurant, food truck and event caterer all provide food, but they solve different service problems. A canteen may need clear choices in a short break. A café may serve customers over a longer period. A caterer may prepare for a known function at another location. The setting affects menu size, how customers order, how food reaches them and which resources the team needs. It is too simple to call one model 'better'; judge how well it serves its intended customers.

A customer needs more than a product that looks appealing. They need accurate information, suitable choices, fair treatment and service that matches what was promised. Some people are choosing according to taste or budget; others need information about ingredients or allergens. NSW Food Authority guidance says food businesses must provide required allergen information for their food, including unpackaged food. A service team should communicate clearly and refer uncertain questions to the person who can verify the information. Guessing from a dish name or reassuring someone without evidence is unsafe. Class activities still follow the teacher's local safety and supervision directions.



Figure 19. Different service settings make different promises to customers. Illustrative course image.

LOOK CLOSELY

What tells you the setting, customer and timing of this service?

MODULE 04 / SECTION 01 / CONNECT

Service settings and customers

Service depends on connected roles. 'Back of house' commonly describes food preparation and kitchen support, while 'front of house' describes customer contact and service. Management coordinates decisions, staffing and standards, but the boundary between roles can change in a small operation. A food truck worker, for example, may both prepare and serve. Handover matters: a customer request must reach the people making or selecting the food, and a change to an item must reach those describing it to customers. Good communication protects both the customer experience and the team's ability to work.

To compare ventures, look at evidence rather than labels. Record the type of customer, the service moment, menu range, ordering method, team roles, information supplied and likely constraints. Ask what the operation does well for its specific setting and what remains unknown. For example, a short menu may be a strength when customers have limited time, provided the available choices meet their needs. A useful comparison ends with a reasoned judgement that links a service feature to the customer it is meant to help.



Figure 20. The setting shapes timing, choice and the way food reaches people. Illustrative course image.

WORDS TO USE

Food service. The provision of prepared food to customers in a particular setting.

Catering. Planning and supplying food for a function or group, often with a defined service time or location.

Front of house. Roles that mainly involve customer contact, ordering and service.

Source pathway: class sequence, NESA 2019 and linked public evidence

MODULE 04 / SECTION 01 / EVIDENCE

Two service settings

WORKED EXAMPLE / A WAY TO REASON

Compare a canteen serving students during a short break with a caterer serving a planned community event. The canteen may value quick, clear ordering; the caterer must coordinate a known group and service time. Neither comparison tells you what a particular local business actually offers without checking it.

YOUR TASK

Compare two contrasting food service settings and judge how each responds to its customers.

1. Name the customer group, ordering method and service timeframe in each setting.

2. Explain how menu range, staff roles and communication suit each setting.

3. Evaluate one strength and one information gap or limitation in your comparison.

Criterion	Setting A	Setting B
Customers		
Timing		
Choice		
Service promise		

FINAL JUDGEMENT / SETTING, CUSTOMER AND LIMITATION

A STRONG RESPONSE

- Uses matched criteria and specific service evidence rather than a simple personal preference.
- Explains how accurate customer information and team communication affect service quality.

MODULE 04 / SECTION 02 / READ

Menus, teams and costs

A catering menu succeeds when customer needs, team capacity and resources fit together.

A menu is a service plan as well as a list of foods. An à la carte menu lets customers choose separately priced items, while a set menu offers a defined combination or limited choices. Neither format is automatically suitable for every event. The number of diners, time available, service style, dietary needs and capacity of the team all influence the choice. A menu description should make choices understandable and provide a pathway for accurate ingredient and allergen information. Do not infer that a dish meets a dietary requirement from a fashionable name or an incomplete ingredient list.

Costs need more than the price of the main ingredient. A planner considers all ingredients, expected portions, packaging or service materials, labour and other running costs that apply to the setting. The amount charged is revenue, not automatically profit. If food is wasted or portions differ from the plan, costs per usable serving may rise. A simple comparison can ask which option gives suitable quality and value within a budget. The aim is not to invent prices for a real business; it is to explain what should be counted and how an estimate can be checked.



Figure 21. A menu and workflow need to fit the team and the brief. Illustrative course image.

LOOK CLOSELY

Which part of this display depends on team coordination?

MODULE 04 / SECTION 02 / CONNECT

Menus, teams and costs

People and time are resources too. A workflow maps tasks in a useful order and identifies dependencies, such as what information must be confirmed before a menu can be finalised. Allocating responsibilities helps a team avoid duplicated work or gaps. A plan also needs communication points: who confirms guest numbers, who checks a change in ingredient information and who tells the service team? A schedule is only a prediction; if conditions change, the team needs to revise it and communicate the reason. Practical work must still follow current teacher directions and local safety procedures.

Evaluation asks whether the menu and workflow achieved the brief. Collect evidence about suitability, consistency, service timing, waste and customer feedback. Compare actual results with intended criteria rather than calling an item successful because it sold once. A smaller, coherent menu might reduce waste and help a team maintain quality, while an additional option might better meet a genuine customer need. A well-argued improvement explains this trade-off and states what information would test the revised plan.



Figure 22. Cost, capacity and likely waste belong in the same decision. Illustrative course image.

WORDS TO USE

À la carte. A menu format in which customers select separately listed and priced items.

Portion yield. The number of usable servings produced from a planned quantity of food.

Revenue. Money received from sales before relevant costs are deducted.

Source pathway: class sequence, NESA 2019 and linked public evidence

MODULE 04 / SECTION 02 / EVIDENCE

Menu and team fit

WORKED EXAMPLE / A WAY TO REASON

A hypothetical event team considers a short set menu and a longer choice menu. It compares guest suitability, the number of servings required, ingredient and service costs, staff capacity and likely waste. The team selects an approach only after checking the event brief and information available.

YOUR TASK

Evaluate a hypothetical catering menu and workflow for a defined group, then justify one improvement.

1. State the customers, service time, menu format and known constraints.

2. Explain how portion yield, at least two cost categories, team roles and accurate food information affect the plan.

3. Compare two possible changes using suitability, service and waste evidence, and justify the better one.

Decision	Evidence	Possible issue
Guest needs		
Team capacity		
Cost		
Likely waste		

FINAL JUDGEMENT / MENU, TEAM AND IMPROVEMENT

A STRONG RESPONSE

- Distinguishes revenue, costs and usable portions while explaining a realistic planning trade-off.
- Gives a specific improvement tied to customer needs, communication and evidence.

MODULE 04 / SECTION 03 / READ

Functional properties and review

Understanding what an ingredient does helps explain food quality and make a reasoned improvement.

An ingredient has more than a flavour. Its functional property is what it can do in a food system: help thicken, hold a mixture together, create a foam or affect structure and moisture. These functions help explain why a product changes during preparation. For example, starch can contribute to thickening when it takes up liquid and is heated, while egg proteins can set and help give structure. An emulsifier can help oil and water remain mixed. The exact result depends on the whole formula and process, so one ingredient name cannot predict a finished product by itself.

Functional properties differ from sensory characteristics. Function explains the ingredient's role and changes during production; sensory characteristics describe what people can see, smell, taste, hear or feel in the finished food. They connect: a change in structure may alter texture, and a change in moisture may alter mouthfeel. A useful explanation follows a chain: ingredient or process, property change, observable result, and whether that result suits the intended food. 'It tasted good' is feedback, but it does not explain why a texture changed.



Figure 23. Ingredients contribute to food texture and other qualities. Illustrative course image.

LOOK CLOSELY

Describe a visible texture difference without claiming its cause yet.

MODULE 04 / SECTION 03 / CONNECT

Functional properties and review

A fair product comparison changes one planned factor at a time where possible and records the conditions and results. If a team changes the ingredient amount, heating time and serving temperature together, it cannot confidently say which caused the difference. Observations should be specific, such as whether a sauce held its shape or separated, rather than simply 'good' or 'bad'. The team should use only approved ingredients, equipment and procedures in practical lessons. This section explains the science for evaluation; it does not set a class recipe or authorise an unsupervised trial.

Reviewing a catering product joins science with service. The question is not just whether a sample works in isolation, but whether its texture, consistency, appearance and suitability can be maintained for the intended customers and service setting. Combine observations with feedback and the original brief. If a product is inconsistent, identify the most likely cause that the evidence supports, propose one change and explain how to test it. A careful review also states what remains uncertain. This is more useful than claiming a single observation proves a universal rule about an ingredient.



Figure 24. A fair comparison changes one factor and records what is actually observed. Illustrative course image.

WORDS TO USE

Functional property. What an ingredient or food component does in a mixture or during preparation.

Sensory characteristic. A quality of food perceived by the senses, such as texture, aroma or appearance.

Controlled comparison. A comparison that keeps relevant conditions consistent while changing a planned factor.

Source pathway: class sequence, NESA 2019 and linked public evidence

MODULE 04 / SECTION 03 / EVIDENCE

Fair texture review

WORKED EXAMPLE / A WAY TO REASON

In a teacher-approved comparison of two hypothetical sauces, students would describe whether each stayed evenly mixed, note which single factor differed and relate the observation to the intended service. They could not claim an ingredient caused the change if several factors changed together.

YOUR TASK

Evaluate a hypothetical catering product whose texture changes during service, using functional-property reasoning and a fair plan for improvement.

1. Describe the observed texture or stability change and why it matters to the intended customers and service.

2. Explain one plausible ingredient or process role, separating the functional property from the sensory result.

3. Propose a teacher-approved controlled comparison, naming the factor to change, conditions to keep consistent and evidence to record.

Sample	Observation	Inference limit
Intended quality		
Sample A		
Sample B		
Next fair test		

FINAL REASONING / TEXTURE, FAIR TEST AND IMPROVEMENT

A STRONG RESPONSE

- Builds a clear ingredient-or-process to property to observable-result explanation with an acknowledged uncertainty.
- Justifies one testable improvement against the service brief without inventing a class recipe or safety procedure.

MODULE 04 / DECISION STUDIO

Service decision studio



Illustrative scene for reasoning; it does not depict this class or a completed task.

Practice scenario: a team must serve a planned group at a set time. Guest needs, staffing and costs must be checked before a menu is confirmed.

BUILD THE DECISION

1. Compare a shorter set menu with a longer choice menu.

2. Explain the likely demands on the team and resources.

3. Recommend what to trial or verify before service.

EVIDENCE / OPTION / REASON / NEXT CHECK

Practice evidence: use the teacher's current Classroom instructions for any formal task.

MODULE 04 / REVIEW AND REFLECT

What can you now explain?

Circle one answer for each check, then use the writing space to correct or extend an idea. These are formative practice questions.

01. In a small food truck, one worker takes orders and prepares food. What does this show?

- ○ A. Separate front- and back-of-house responsibilities no longer need planning when one person does both.
- ○ B. Customer contact and food preparation become the same task when done by one worker.
- ○ C. Front- and back-of-house tasks can be combined in one role.

02. Which cost list is most complete for comparing two catering proposals?

- ○ A. Ingredients and packaging only, assuming staff time is identical across proposals.
- ○ B. Ingredients, portions, service materials, labour and relevant running costs.
- ○ C. Ingredient cost and forecast selling prices, treating the sales forecast as a cost.

03. Why is 'egg always gives the same result' a weak prediction?

- ○ A. The result depends on the whole food system and process.
- ○ B. Egg's effect is set only by the amount used, regardless of the other ingredients.
- ○ C. Egg has the same functional role in every mixture, although the final appearance may vary.

CORRECT OR EXTEND ONE ANSWER

EVIDENCE KEPT IN THIS MODULE

- ☐ I can point to a source or observation.
- ☐ I have compared more than one factor.
- ☐ I have named a limit or unanswered question.

ONE IDEA I WOULD IMPROVE AFTER FEEDBACK